

know what you're looking for and you do some research, you can find a decent deal. Your goal is to find coverage that will help you pay for a major medical problem. Policies that cover anything more may be prohibitively expensive, depending on where you live. You may find it necessary to pay for routine medical services with your own money and to rely on your health insurance to protect you only in case of a medical catastrophe.

If you've developed an illness or condition that would otherwise make you uninsurable, you're probably entitled to individual coverage if you had insurance at your last job within the last couple of months. That's because your right to be insured is protected by HIPAA. The gist: Once you've exhausted your 18 months of COBRA coverage, you are entitled to **guaranteed-issue individual coverage (GIIC)**. The premiums for GIIC can be very high, but some states will subsidize them, making them somewhat more affordable. Call or email your state insurance agency (Figure 8–1) for more information.

For a good brochure that spells out your rights, get a copy of the Department of Labor's publication *Your Health Plan and HIPAA...Making the Law Work for You* (www.dol.gov/ebsa/publications/yhphipaa.html).

No matter where you get a policy, make sure it doesn't offer such skimpy protection that it's worthless. Try to find a policy that meets these conditions:

- **It covers at least 80% of your hospital, surgery, and inhospital doctor bills once you meet the deductible.** Ideally, you'd be able to find a policy that covers 100%, but this type of coverage can be prohibitively expensive. With a policy that covers 80%, you'll have to pay the remaining 20% out of your own pocket. To avoid getting hit with tremendous medical expenses, look for a policy that caps your annual out-of-pocket costs at around \$3,000 (or whatever you can comfortably afford after paying the deductible).
- **It has a maximum lifetime benefit of at least \$1 million.** A lifetime cap is the dollar limit the insurance company will pay over the course of the policy. While a given health condition might not cost that much to treat, remember that